

Power outage / Blackout

A blackout is a large-scale power failure that lasts for a long period of time, occurs suddenly, and affects several countries or even continents. The consequences of a blackout are difficult to estimate, as there are simply no empirical values. One speaks of a blackout only when several parts of the country are affected at the same time. Local disruptions in federal states or outages lasting several hours are not blackouts.

Causes of a blackout

There could be several reasons for smaller power outages or a large area-wide power outage. Most power outages are caused by weather events, such as lightning and storms, as well as natural disasters.

Furthermore, short interruptions can occur due to strong fluctuations of the mains voltage in the power grid. In most cases, these can be quickly resolved by the operator.

Increasingly, the power grid is becoming a victim of sabotage or cyber-terrorism. In the future, the power grid will be better secured against these threats through encryption algorithms.

Possible effects

In a summer blackout, the days are light longer and there is no heating, so the damage to private households will be small. However, refrigerated food in the refrigerators will spoil because there is no electricity to operate them.

A winter blackout, on the other hand, is a prolonged power outage far more serious since the heating and stove for warming meals are missing.

In offices and businesses, computers, printers, copiers, telephones, and other electrical equipment stop working, forcing the economy to succumb. Likewise, it becomes more difficult for employees to get to work as traffic lights, roads and subways break down.

In supermarkets it is no longer possible to pay at the cash registers.

Frozen and perishable goods can no longer be refrigerated. In addition, ATMs cannot be operated, and cash withdrawals are reduced.

Personal action and prevention

In the event of a prolonged power outage, purchasing food and beverages will likely not be possible. For this reason, every household should stock up on the following items:

- Food and beverage stock
- Candles and flashlight with spare batteries
- Camping stove

- Crank radio or battery radio with spare batteries
- First aid - civil defense pharmacy
- Cash
- Hygiene items

The following statistics describe the power outages over the period from 2002 to 2020. Using the column on the right, you can see how the power outages have broken down in 2020.

